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The Customer Journey

Meet buyers at every stage

From *Business Transformation Through AI-Powered Marketing*, the Field Guide for Small Businesses and Marketing Teams

Mike Huber with Loren Ankarlo

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HOW TO USE THIS FIELD GUIDE

Read it. Build it. Then let AI help.

This is one of 21 field guides. Use it on its own, or as part of a complete transformation.

Read. Each section gives you the background, the best practices and real examples, including Wild West Custom Pools, a real business going through the same steps you are.

Build. Fill in the forms, in this printed guide or in the interactive PDF. Your answers are the raw material for your plan.

Accelerate with AI. The AI Tips turn your answers into first drafts, analyses and action plans. You think. AI drafts. You decide.

You think. AI drafts. You decide.

Before you start

Do two things first, whichever guide you start with: agree on the AI ground rules (people approve everything public; verify facts; protect data; keep your voice; add what AI can't), and write down your one-year goal and your ideal customer. Field Guides 01 and 02 walk you through both.

Your free extras

Bought the printed guide? The interactive PDF is yours too. Go to marketingfieldguide.ai/pdf and enter the code on the copyright page. The companion workbook (Excel) does the math for every table: marketingfieldguide.ai.

05

FIELD GUIDE 05

The Customer Journey

Meet buyers at every stage

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The Customer Journey

> **"There is only one valid definition of business purpose: to create a customer."**
>
> **PETER DRUCKER**
> The Practice of Management (1954)

Every step a buyer takes on the way to a purchase, and beyond it.

Your customers don't buy in a straight line. But they do buy in predictable ways. They notice a problem. They research. They compare. They decide. If you treat them well, they come back and send their friends.

The customer journey maps those steps. It shows you where buyers find you, what they need to know at each point, and where they drop out. Every piece of content you publish should serve one stage of that journey and move the buyer to the next one.

In this chapter you will:

- Define the stages of your own customer journey
- Score how well your marketing supports each stage
- Find the dead ends where buyers fall out
- Map the touchpoints for each of your personas
- List the questions your buyers need answered

What AI changed

The stages are the same as they were in 2023. What changed is where the early stages happen.

More of your buyer's research now happens inside an AI answer. They ask Google, ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini or Perplexity a full question and get a summary back. They may form an opinion of you before they ever reach your website.

The numbers show it. Seer Interactive tracked 5.47 million searches for 53 brands from January 2025 to February 2026. In February 2026, when a Google AI Overview appeared, 2.36% of organic impressions turned into a click. When none appeared, 3.82% did. Questions are the most likely to get an AI answer: a Washington University in St. Louis study of 55,393 Google searches in spring 2026 found AI Overviews on about 65% of searches phrased as questions, compared with 13.7% of all searches.

The companies' own data points the same way. In a September 2026 court filing, publishers suing OpenAI and Microsoft cite internal Microsoft data showing that clicks to The New York Times's websites were 87% to 93% lower from Bing Chat than from regular Bing search. They also quote a 2023 message from an

OpenAI engineer: "No matter how prominently we show the links, users won't click" (Search Engine Journal, 2026). These are claims in an ongoing lawsuit, not a court finding, but they match what independent research shows.

The consideration stage is hit hardest. In Seer Interactive's 2026 data, 95.4% of comparison searches showed an AI Overview (Seer Interactive, 2026). When a buyer is weighing options, an AI answer is now usually standing between you and them.

That matters for the journey in two ways:

- **Awareness and consideration can happen without a visit.** The AI answer may be your first touchpoint. You don't control it, but you can feed it. Clear, specific, consistent facts about who you serve, where, and at what price give AI tools something accurate to say.
- **Your buyers ask questions.** The first edition said the customer journey is nothing more than a series of questions that must be answered. That is truer now. The searches most likely to get an AI answer are the ones written as questions. The business with the clearest answers wins the mention.

The AI Search Visibility section of the SEO chapter (Chapter 6) goes deeper on how to earn those mentions. This chapter makes sure your journey has no gaps for AI, or a buyer, to fall into.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Hero graphic.

THE FIVE STAGES

The five stages

Most journeys follow five stages. Yours may have more or fewer, and you'll define your own later in this chapter. Start here.

STAGE	WHAT THE BUYER IS ASKING	EXAMPLE TOUCHPOINTS
Awareness	"I have a problem. What are my options?"	AI answers, search results, social posts, video, PR, events, word of mouth, paid ads
Consideration	"Who can solve it, and how do they compare?"	Blog posts, comparison pages, reviews, case studies, webinars, retargeting ads, email
Decision	"Can I trust them? What does it cost? What happens next?"	Pricing pages, landing pages, FAQs, guarantees, demos, chat, a phone call
Retention	"Did I make the right choice?"	Onboarding, how-to content, check-ins, loyalty offers, personalized email

STAGE	WHAT THE BUYER IS ASKING	EXAMPLE TOUCHPOINTS
Advocacy	"Who should I tell?"	Review requests, referral programs, user-generated content, social sharing, surveys

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Redraw the first edition's journey wave (p.

Questions to ask at each stage

Each stage is a set of questions your buyer needs answered. Before you can answer theirs, answer these. Work through them with your team, and use what you know from real customers, not guesses.

Awareness. The buyer has a problem, or is about to. They don't know you yet. Ask:

- What problem sends people looking for a business like ours, and what happens just before they start looking?
- What words do they use to describe it, in search, in AI assistants and to friends?
- Where do they go to learn about it?
- What could we publish that helps them, even if they never hire us?
- What would make them want to know more about us?

Your Awareness answers:

Consideration. The buyer knows what they need and is comparing options. Ask:

- What are they comparing us with, including doing it themselves or doing nothing?
- What do they read, watch or ask while they compare?
- What trade-offs do they see between their options?
- When an AI assistant compares businesses like ours, what does it say about us?

Your Consideration answers:

Decision. The buyer has a short list, and we're on it. Ask:

- What finally tips the choice: price, proof, timing, trust or something else?
- What do customers who chose us say made the difference?
- What doubts are still in the way, and where do we answer them?
- What do they expect to happen after they say yes?

Your Decision answers:

Retention. The buyer has paid and is asking, “Did I make the right choice?” The first few weeks decide whether they buy again, and whether they'll ever recommend you. Ask:

- What does a new customer need in the first 30 days to feel they made the right choice?
- What questions or problems come up after the sale, and how fast do we answer them?
- How and when do we check in, and who owns it?
- What would make them buy from us again, or buy more?

Your Retention answers:

Advocacy. Happy customers can bring you the next ones, if you make it easy. Ask:

- Which customers are most like the buyers we want more of?
- What part of their experience would persuade someone like them?
- What questions could they answer better than we can?
- How will we ask for their review or story, and where will we share it?

Your Advocacy answers:

Your answers show where each stage is strong and where buyers get stuck. Use them to plan the content, pages and follow-up that move a buyer from one stage to the next, until they buy again and bring others with them.

AI TIP

Answer the stage questions with your customers' own words

```
Context: We sell [product or service] to [type of customer] in [market]. Below are real
customer words: [paste reviews, emails, sales-call notes, chat logs or survey answers, with
names and personal details removed].

Role: Act as a customer research analyst.

Ask: Using only this material, draft answers to the customer journey questions for the
[Awareness, Consideration, Decision, Retention or Advocacy] stage.

Format: A table with three columns: the question, the draft answer, and the customer quote that
supports it. Then a list of the questions this material can't answer.

Tighten: Don't guess. If the material doesn't answer a question, say so. Keep my customers'
wording where you can.
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The questions AI can't answer are your research list. Take them to your customers, your sales team and whoever answers your phone.

Some journeys are fast, some are slow

The stages are the same for every buyer. The time it takes to move through them is not. Someone buying hiking boots or a printer may go from Awareness to Decision in an afternoon. Someone buying a car, project-management software for a whole company or a custom pool may take months, with many touchpoints and more than one decision maker along the way.

The longer the journey, the more content and follow-up it needs, and the more places a buyer can fall out. A Wild West Custom Pools project starts at $90,000. Nobody buys that on a first visit. That's one reason the site publishes its price tiers early: it answers a Decision question while the buyer is still in Consideration.

How long is your typical journey, from first contact to purchase? Is it the same for every persona? _____

Beware the dead-end journey

A dead end is any point where a buyer is ready for the next step and finds nothing there.

The first edition's example still holds. A buyer finds you, learns about your product, decides it solves their problem and clicks to buy. The product is out of stock. Momentum gone. Often the buyer goes to a competitor.

Dead ends are usually quieter than that:

- A blog post with no next step or call to action
- A service page with no pricing range, so the buyer can't tell if you fit their budget
- A form that nobody answers for three days
- A happy customer who is never asked for a review

There is now a new kind: **the AI dead end.** A buyer asks an AI assistant about your category in your city. The answer names three competitors, not you. Or it names you with old prices, the wrong service area or a service you dropped. The buyer never reaches your site to find out otherwise. You can't fully control what AI tools say. You can make sure your website, your Google Business Profile and your review profiles all state the same clear, current facts.

PRO TIP: Audit for dead ends the way your buyer travels. Don't audit page by page. Pick one persona and walk the whole journey as them, from the first search to the thank-you email after the sale. Every time you hit a page with no clear next step, write it down. That list is your fix-it list.

The opposite mistake: pushing too soon

Dead ends lose buyers by giving them nothing. You can also lose them by giving them too much, too early.

Picture downloading a guide and getting a sales call before you've finished the first page. Most buyers don't want that. In Gartner's survey of 632 B2B buyers, 73% said they actively avoid suppliers who send irrelevant outreach, and 61% said they would rather buy without talking to a sales rep at all (Gartner, 2025). A call that comes too early isn't help. It's a reason to go elsewhere.

The lesson: match your follow-up to the buyer's stage. A first download is Awareness or early Consideration. Nurture it with more useful content. Watch for signs that a buyer is getting ready: repeat visits, a look at your pricing page, a second or third download, a direct question. Save the sales call for that buyer, or for the one who asks for it. A simple question on your form, such as "Would you like someone to contact you?", lets buyers tell you themselves.

Match your follow-up to the buyer's stage, not your sales target.

(Chapter 16, Lead Nurture, covers how to score leads and when to hand them to sales.)

Score your touchpoints

Score how well your marketing supports each stage of the journey. Use one score per box.

Score each box 0–5 **0** not used at this stage **1–2** just beginning **3–4** in use, results unclear **5** in use, results clear

Add across for each discipline's total (up to 25). Add down for each stage's total (up to 50). The grand total is out of 250.

DISCIPLINE	AWARENESS	CONSIDERATION	DECISION	RETENTION	ADVOCACY	TOTAL
Strategy (personas, positioning, messaging)						
Content						
SEO and AI search						
Paid media (search, social, display, retargeting)						
Social media						
Email and marketing automation						
Video						
Website and conversion optimization						
Local SEO and reviews						
Analytics						
Total by stage						**/ 250**

The AI layer. Now score how far AI is built into your workflows at each stage. Use the AI fluency ladder from Chapter 3. This row is scored separately and does not count toward your 250-point total.

- **Level 1, Not started:** no AI at this stage
- **Level 2, Experimenting:** someone tries AI here now and then
- **Level 3, Using regularly:** AI is used here most weeks, by habit, not by process
- **Level 4, Integrated:** AI is a written step in the workflow, with a person approving the output

	AWARENESS	CONSIDERATION	DECISION	RETENTION	ADVOCACY
AI in our workflows (Level 1–4)					

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

In the final layout, set this row directly under the scorecard.

Offline and in-person touchpoints you rely on (events, trade shows, direct mail, phone calls, in-store visits, sales outreach): _____

↓ Touchpoint scorecard in the companion workbook. Stage totals

What your total score reveals

TOTAL SCORE	WHAT IT MEANS
0–50	We need help. Start with one stage and one discipline.
51–100	You're a beginner, with dead-end gaps.
101–150	You're getting there, with room to improve.
151–200	You're strong in many areas. Look for the gaps.
201–250	You cover the whole journey. Keep testing and improving.

A perfect score isn't the goal. Not every discipline belongs in every stage. Paid media may matter little in Advocacy, and review requests matter little in Awareness. The question is whether a low score sits in a stage where your buyers expect to find you. Look at the stage totals first. The lowest stage total is usually your biggest dead end.

Customer journey checklist

- **Look at your lowest stage.** Which stage scored lowest? What would a buyer at that stage need from you that they can't find today?
- **Look for zeros.** Which disciplines are you not using at all? Decide whether each one is a real gap or simply not relevant to your buyers.
- **Look at your lowest AI stage.** What's one workflow at your lowest AI stage you could take to Level 4 this quarter? The AI layer table later in this chapter shows where to start.
- **Check your resources.** Low scores often point to missing skills, not missing effort. Compare this scorecard to your skills assessment in Chapter 3.
- **Document your needs.** A completed scorecard is evidence. Use it to show leadership where you need budget, people or training.

As you consider your total score: Where are your gaps? What will you fix first, and what resources will it take? _____

MAP YOUR CUSTOMER JOURNEY

Map your customer journey

Now build your own. You'll define your stages, check your content mix, list your buyers' questions and map the journey for each persona.

PRO TIP: Put yourself in your customer's shoes. Map the journey from their side, not yours. At each stage, ask what they are trying to get done, what they are feeling, and what they'll do next because of that feeling.

A buyer who just found you wants information. A buyer who just paid wants reassurance.

PRO TIP: Build the map with the people who talk to customers. Get stakeholder buy-in first. Then hold discovery meetings with sales, customer service and anyone else on the front line. They hear the real questions every day. Check what they tell you against your analytics, so you have both the numbers and the reasons behind them. Then align sales and marketing on the stages, so both teams use the same map.

Step 1: Define your stages

My customer journey stages (start with the five above; rename, add or combine to fit how your buyers really buy):

Step 2: Check your content mix

Each piece of content should help a buyer at one stage take the next step, or skip a step. Count the content you have published in the last 12 months and sort it by stage. Then set a goal.

YOUR TURN

STAGE	CURRENT % OF CONTENT	GOAL % OF CONTENT
Awareness		
Consideration		
Decision		
Retention		

STAGE	CURRENT % OF CONTENT	GOAL % OF CONTENT
Advocacy		
Total	**100%**	**100%**

Need a starting goal? In our 2019 book, we suggested putting 50% of your content into Awareness, 30% into Consideration, 15% into Decision and 5% into Advocacy. Two things have changed since then. AI answers now take many of the clicks that Awareness content used to earn (see "What AI changed" earlier in this chapter, and Chapter 6). And this edition adds Retention as its own stage. Here's an updated starting point:

STAGE	2019 STARTING POINT	2026 STARTING POINT
Awareness	50%	30%
Consideration	30%	25%
Decision	15%	25%
Retention	(not a separate stage)	10%
Advocacy	5%	10%

The research points the same way. Buyers want to make up their own minds. In Gartner's survey of 632 B2B buyers, released in June 2025, 61% said they prefer to buy without talking to a sales rep, and 73% actively avoid suppliers who send irrelevant outreach (Gartner, 2025). A year later, Gartner found that buyers used an average of seven information sources during a purchase, and 45% used AI tools to research vendors and products (Gartner, 2026). If buyers are deciding on their own, your pricing, comparisons, FAQs and proof must be there when they look.

Keeping customers pays, too. Acquiring a new customer costs five to 25 times more than keeping one, and Bain's Frederick Reichheld found that a 5% increase in retention increases profits by 25% to 95% (Harvard Business Review, 2014).

These percentages are starting points, not rules. Adjust them for your industry, your buyers and the length of your sales cycle.

My years of experience have shown that most businesses are heavy in Awareness and thin in Decision and Retention. Decision content (pricing, comparisons, FAQs, proof) is often what closes the sale.

Step 3: List the questions your buyers ask

The customer journey is nothing more than a series of questions that must be answered. Your buyers now type those questions, word for word, into AI tools and search engines.

What are the top questions buyers must have answered before they buy from you? Note the stage for each.

QUESTION	STAGE	WHERE WE ANSWER IT TODAY (PAGE OR ASSET)

Any question without an answer in the third column is a dead end.

Step 4: Map the journey by persona

Different buyers take different paths. A homeowner and a property manager may buy the same service for different reasons, through different channels. Map one journey per persona, using the personas you defined in Chapter 2.

Persona name: _____

STAGE	WHAT THEY NEED	TOUCHPOINTS AND CHANNELS	CONTENT WE HAVE	CONTENT WE NEED
Awareness				
Consideration				
Decision				

STAGE	WHAT THEY NEED	TOUCHPOINTS AND CHANNELS	CONTENT WE HAVE	CONTENT WE NEED
Retention				
Advocacy				

Repeat for a second persona.

Same product, two journeys. In our 2019 book, we used a home solar company to show how two personas can buy the same product for different reasons. One homeowner wants to cut their utility bill. The other wants to go green. Each needs different content at every stage:

STAGE	PERSONA 1: WANTS TO SAVE MONEY	PERSONA 2: WANTS TO GO GREEN
Awareness	"4 things raising your utility bill you didn't know about"	"10 ways to make your home greener"
Consideration	"Tax credits for homeowners who add solar"	"The best U.S. cities for generating your own solar power"
Decision	"Why buying solar panels saves more than leasing"	"How to choose an environmentally responsible solar installer"

When you build your own map, every blank square is a content gap. If you leave it blank, a competitor will fill it.

Questions to ask at each stage. Use your answers to the stage questions earlier in this chapter as you fill in the map.

↓ **Persona journey map and question list in the companion workbook**

Step 5: Plan how you'll ask for reviews

Reviews sit at the end of one buyer's journey and the start of the next. In BrightLocal's 2026 survey of 1,002 U.S. consumers, 97% said they read reviews for local businesses. The same survey found that the share of consumers using ChatGPT and other AI tools for local recommendations jumped from 6% to 45% in a year, and those tools draw on what your reviews say (BrightLocal, 2026).

Most happy customers won't write a review unless you ask. But when asked, most do: 83% of the people asked to leave a review in BrightLocal's survey went on to leave one. So ask, and make it easy:

- Ask in person when the job is done, then follow up with a short email or text with a direct link to your review page. Your Google Business Profile can generate that link.
- Give them a few questions to answer, so they aren't facing a blank box: What did you buy from us? What did you like best? Why did you choose us over the alternatives? Would you recommend us, and to whom?
- Respond to every review, good or bad, in your own voice. Use negative reviews as training. Look for patterns and fix the cause.
- Ask every customer, not just the ones you expect to be happy. Google prohibits selectively asking for positive reviews. Never pay for a review or offer anything in exchange for one. It's now federal law, not just platform policy: the FTC's rule on consumer reviews took effect in October 2024, and in December 2025 the FTC began sending warning letters, with civil penalties of up to $53,088 per violation (see Chapter 8, Local SEO and Reviews).

When and how will we ask each customer for a review? Who owns it? _____

AI TIP

Draft your review request

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Context: I run [business name], a [business type] in [city]. A customer, [first name only],
just finished [project or purchase]. Our review link is [link].

Role: Act as a customer service lead who writes warm, short messages.

Ask: Write a review request I can send by email and a shorter version for text. Thank them for
something specific about their project, ask for a review, and include three easy questions they
can answer: what they bought, what they liked best and why they chose us.

Format: Email under 120 words with a subject line; text under 300 characters.

Tighten: No pressure, no incentives, no exclamation points. It should sound like me, not like a
template.
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Let AI do the first draft

You think, AI drafts, you decide. The answers you just wrote are the context AI needs. Paste them in.

AI TIP: Draft your journey stages and buyer questions

Context: I run [business type] serving [customer type] in [market or location]. Our main offer is [product or service] at [price range]. Here are notes from our sales and service team on what buyers ask: [paste notes, FAQs or anonymized emails]. Role: Act as a customer journey strategist who has mapped journeys for small and mid-size businesses. Ask: Propose the stages of our customer journey, from first awareness to advocacy. For each stage, list the top five questions our buyers ask. Format: A table with columns: Stage, Buyer's goal, Top questions, Emotion at this stage. Tighten: Use our buyers' own words where the notes allow. Flag any question you added that isn't in my notes.

AI TIP: Build a journey map for one persona

Context: Here is our persona: [paste persona from Chapter 2]. Here are our journey stages and the channels we use: [paste stages and channels, including paid media]. Role: Act as a digital marketing strategist. Ask: Map this persona's journey. For each stage, give their need, the three touchpoints most likely to reach them, and one piece of content that would move them to the next stage. Format: One table, one row per stage. Tighten: Only recommend channels from my list. Mark any touchpoint where we have no content today.

AI TIP: Find what your customers feel at each stage

Context: Here are [number] customer reviews, survey answers and support emails, with names and personal details removed: [paste text]. Role: Act as a customer research analyst. Ask: Sort each comment by journey stage. Find the top pain points, worries and moments of delight at each stage. Format: A table by stage with pain points, worries and delights, each with one short example quote. Tighten: Quote only from the text I gave you. Don't invent customer quotes. Tell me which stages have too little feedback to judge.

Protect your data: remove names, emails, phone numbers and account details before you paste customer feedback into any AI tool. Check your company's AI policy for what can be shared.

THE AI LAYER ON YOUR JOURNEY

The AI layer on your journey

"You've got to start with the customer experience and work backwards to the technology."

STEVE JOBS
Apple Worldwide Developers Conference (1997)

AI can help at every stage. It drafts, sorts, tests and personalizes. People still approve everything public, check the facts and add what AI can't: real experience, real proof and judgment.

STAGE	WHERE AI HELPS	WHAT STAYS WITH PEOPLE
Awareness	Turning buyer questions into content ideas; drafting ad variations for paid media; checking what AI assistants say about your category	Choosing which questions you can answer best; final approval of every ad and post
Consideration	Drafting comparison pages and FAQs; summarizing reviews into themes; building retargeting audiences inside ad platforms	Real case studies, real numbers, your point of view
Decision	Website chat that answers common questions; drafting landing pages; testing headlines and offers	Pricing, guarantees and promises; the sales conversation
Retention	Personalizing onboarding and follow-up emails; spotting customers who have gone quiet	The relationship; how you handle problems
Advocacy	Drafting review requests and referral emails; sorting feedback by theme	Asking in person; thanking people; responding to reviews in your own voice

AI TIP: Check for AI dead ends

Context: I run [business name], a [business type] in [city or region]. We serve [customer type] and our prices run [price range]. Role: Act as a buyer researching this category for the first time. Ask: Answer these as you normally would: "Who are the best [category] providers in [city]?" "How much does [service] cost in [city]?" "What should I look for when hiring a [category]?" Format: Your normal answers, then a list of every business you named. Tighten: Run the same prompt in two or three AI tools and in Google. Record whether you appear, what is said about you, and whether it is accurate. Repeat every quarter.

This AI TIP is a test, not a fix. If you don't appear, or the facts are wrong, the fix is on your own properties: your website, Google Business Profile and review profiles. The AI Search Visibility section of Chapter 6 covers how.

AI TIP: Audit your content for dead ends

Context: Here are our journey stages: [paste stages]. Here is a list of our web pages, blog posts, emails and ads, with a one-line description of each: [paste list]. Role: Act as a conversion strategist auditing a customer journey. Ask: Assign each item to a stage. Then find the gaps: stages with little or no content, and pages with no clear next step. Format: A table of items by stage, then a numbered list of the ten most important gaps, each with one suggested fix. Tighten: Base the audit only on the list I gave you. Rank the gaps by how close the buyer is to buying, with Decision-stage gaps first.

AI TIP: Turn your scorecard into an action plan

Context: Here is our touchpoint scorecard, scored 0 to 5 by discipline and stage: [paste scorecard]. Our team is [team size and roles] and our monthly marketing budget is [amount]. Role: Act as a marketing director planning the next 90 days. Ask: Find our three biggest gaps and propose a 90-day plan to close them. Format: A table with Gap, Why it matters, Action, Owner, Cost, and How we'll measure it. Tighten: Stay within our budget and team. Include paid media where it fits. Tell me what you would not do yet, and why.

Example: Wild West Custom Pools

Wild West Custom Pools builds custom pools in the Austin metro. In June 2026 the company repositioned from a general builder to a boutique luxury builder, using Claude for the research, positioning, website and ad plan. (Chapter 4 tells the full story.) The new site and ad plan were built around the journey of a high-end homeowner.

STAGE	THE BUYER'S REAL QUESTION	WHAT WILD WEST BUILT
Awareness	"Who builds luxury pools near me?"	Google Search ads on luxury and local pool-builder keywords; a Google Business Profile set up first; Facebook and Instagram ads with the best pool photos
Consideration	"Will this builder disappear on me?"	A message aimed straight at that fear: the owner is on-site from excavation to first swim, and clients get his direct number. A gallery of real pools. Eight real Google reviews.
Decision	"Can I afford this, and how does it work?"	Three published price tiers ($90K–$150K, $150K–$350K, $350K+), an FAQ, a clear consultation process with Zoom design meetings, and a contact form tested until every inquiry arrived
Retention and Advocacy	"Who should I tell?"	Planned: each finished pool becomes a visible referral in its neighborhood, with Nextdoor added once enough pools are built

Two choices stand out. First, the site publishes prices. That answers the Decision question early and keeps buyers who don't fit the budget from becoming dead-end leads. One of the Google ads does the same: it leads with "Custom Pools From $90K." Second, a retargeting ad follows site visitors who didn't inquire. It brings Consideration-stage buyers back instead of losing them.

We asked Dan what buyers ask most in the first meeting. He named two questions: "How much is this going to cost?" and "When can we swim?" Both are Decision-stage questions, and buyers bring them to the very first conversation. The published price tiers answer the first one before a buyer ever calls. Dan's answer to the second: a custom gunite pool typically takes 12 to 16 weeks to build once excavation begins, depending on the design and permitting. An honest answer like that belongs on the site, too, so buyers don't have to wait for a meeting to hear it.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Wild West journey strip: five rounded cards.

CUSTOMER JOURNEY MAPPING QUESTIONS

Customer journey mapping questions

Answer these with your team. Then paste your answers into your AI assistant with the action-plan AI TIP above.

1. How do customers become aware of us? Which channels do they use to find us: search, AI assistants, social media, paid ads, referrals or something else? [FORM FIELD]
2. When we ask AI assistants about our category and city, do we appear? Is what they say accurate? [FORM FIELD]
3. What key factors do buyers weigh when they evaluate us? What information do they need to decide? [FORM FIELD]
4. What does the path to purchase look like? What barriers or friction could stop a buyer from buying? [FORM FIELD]
5. Do we have content that answers our buyers' pain points and needs at every stage? Where are the dead ends? [FORM FIELD]
6. What can we do to reduce friction in the purchase? Are our pricing and payment options clear? [FORM FIELD]
7. Are we using the right mix of channels, including SEO and AI search, paid media, social media, email and content? [FORM FIELD]
8. How can we create a customer experience good enough to earn loyalty? [FORM FIELD]
9. How do we turn satisfied customers into advocates? What are our touchpoints for reviews and referrals? [FORM FIELD]
10. Which metrics will we track at each stage? Examples: search and AI visibility, website traffic, engagement, conversion rate, cost per lead, repeat purchases and review volume. [FORM FIELD]

↓ All Chapter 5 worksheets in the companion workbook: touchpoint scorecard

SOURCES

Sources

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